

Production Buddy

How-To Guide — step-by-step usage for each tab

v1.0.12

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Overview

Production Buddy is a macOS desktop app with three top tabs in the header. Each tab handles a different production workflow. This guide walks through every input on every tab, in the order you fill them in, using the same circled-number labels (①, ②, ③...) that appear in the UI.

Tab 1 — Marked-up PDF → InDesign Edits (*default tab*)

What it does: Reads reviewer markup from a PDF and applies the corresponding edits to the source InDesign or Illustrator file, then re-exports a corrected PDF.

Steps

- ① **Marked-up PDF** — Browse to the PDF that contains reviewer comments (strikethroughs, sticky notes, carets, highlights, etc.).
- ② **Source Document (.indd or .ai)** — The original InDesign or Illustrator file the markup applies to. The app auto-detects which engine to run from the extension.
- ③ **Output Folder** (*optional*) — Where the new .indd and exported PDF land. Defaults to the same folder as the source.
- ④ **Hi-res images folder** (*optional*) — A folder of hi-res stock-photo files. The app reads each placed image's stock-photo ID (Getty / AdobeStock / Shutterstock numeric ID) and re-links any watermarked comps to the matching hi-res file. Works with or without an ICF_ prefix.
- ⑤ **Reference files** (*optional*) — Other assets the markup mentions (extra .indd, .pdf, .ai, .psd, images). Used when the markup says things like “append the rebate sheet” or “place the logo here”.
- ⑥ **Brand Guide** (*optional*) — Browse to a brand-guide PDF (the official one for this brand) so the app can enforce approved swatches and fonts during QA. Tick “Save to memory” to add it to the persistent library, give it a name (e.g. Acme), and the next time you pick an .indd whose filename contains that name (e.g. Acme_Q3_Flyer .indd) the app auto-loads the saved guide. If the filename matches two saved guides, a picker pops up to let you choose.
- ⑦ **508 compliance check** (*checkbox*) — Runs Section 508 designer-side checks: text/background contrast $\geq 4.5:1$, line weights $\geq 1\text{pt}$, alt text on images, document metadata (title/author/subject/keywords), and forces “Create Tagged PDF” on export.
- ⑧ **Click “Extract & Apply Edits”** — Watch progress in the status panel; QA findings appear below when complete.

Tab 2 — Batch Data Merge

What it does: Generates one .indd per record from a tagged template plus an Excel/CSV data source.

Steps

- ① **Tagged InDesign template (.indd)** — A template where placeholders are tagged like <<placeholder>> instead of literal values. The app produces a placeholders.md reference from your Excel files to guide tagging.
- ② **Data source** — Choose Excel files (one workbook with one sheet per record, row 1 = headers, row 2 = values) OR an existing CSV (row 1 = headers, one row per record).
- ③ **Per-record images folder (optional)** — A folder of per-record graphics named after each record (e.g. California SEP Map.ai, Texas Office Photo.jpg). Supports .ai, .pdf, .eps, .png, .jpg, .tif, .psd. The app matches them by name and adds an @image column to the merged CSV — drag @image from InDesign's Data Merge panel onto a frame to auto-place.
- ④ **Output folder** — One file per record, named <TemplateName>_<RecordName>.indd.
- ⑤ **Record-name column (optional, default "state")** — The CSV column whose value becomes the suffix in each output filename.
- ⑥ **Click "Run Data Merge".**

Tab 3 — Tag a Template

What it does: Takes an InDesign file built for a single record (e.g. one US state) and replaces that record's values with <<placeholder>> tokens, producing a Data Merge-ready template.

Steps

- ① **Untagged InDesign template (.indd)** — The original file built for one record. Save a backup first — the file is rewritten in place unless you supply an output path.
- ② **Excel data files (.xlsx)** — The same workbooks Batch Data Merge uses. The app reads the reference state's values to know what to look for in the template.
- ③ **Reference state** (*default "California"*) — The state your template was originally designed for.
- ④ **Output location** (*optional*) — Where to save the tagged copy. Blank = overwrite the original.
- ⑤ **Click "Auto-Tag Template"**.

Appendix — Settings (*gear icon, top-right*)

Classifier cascade

Rule-based matcher is always on. Optionally enable a local Ollama model to interpret ambiguous markup. Default Ollama model: `llama3.1:8b`. Everything runs locally — nothing leaves the machine.

QA thresholds

- Image min DPI — default **300**
- Max distinct fonts — default **4**
- Max body-text size for rich-black warning — default **14pt**

QA checks enabled

Toggle individual checks off if they're noisy for your workflow.

Output behavior

- Auto-relink missing assets from Box
- Auto-activate fonts via FontExplorer X Pro
- Auto-open PDF when complete
- Auto-open .indd when complete
- Show info-severity findings by default

Cache

Each run writes intermediate logs/JSON to `~/Library/Caches/indesign-editor/`. Default retention: **10** most recent runs.

Ignored findings

IDs you've dismissed will be hidden in future runs.